Day Two

By Kevin W. Burke

INTRODUCTION

There is growing consensus among researchers and educators that the single most important factor in determining a student's performance is the quality of his or her teacher. Yet, every school day, nearly a thousand teachers leave the field of teaching. One teacher voiced her reason for leaving after 16 years: "I can neither teach them properly nor fight for their education while trapped in silent submission."

Submission to government imposed "teaching methods and evaluations" that have become more important than the people engaged in this most important endeavor - learning.

In Day Two by Kevin W. Burke, we hear the inner voice of a substitute teacher and what he or she WISHES to say to the students. But instead – where education is concerned - the "silent submission" epidemic continues and is actually passed along to the students themselves. Day Two by Kevin W. Burke

So, I come from a long line of

bartenders,

sweat-breakers,

broken backs from digging ditches,

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and a few teachers.

Mom taught math,

Sis' teaches English,

and Dad

told us stories.

Now, all of this spins around in my mind

and I see it spinning faster and faster

in the reflection in the eyes of the student

whose face is only inches from mine

as he says,

"What are you gonna do about it if I don't"

all puffer fish, pointy chested

as the rest of the high school class waits.

Waits

as I feel the ink

beneath my long sleeves,

buttons, and slacks

begin to burn.

Waits

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as my first mosh-pit branded brain
begins to boil.
Waits as I keep back the gasoline bile
and get all choked up on
the hand-grenade pins and needles
that have been planted in my throat
and grown a drum set in my jawbone
I play
in time
with the swaying picket signs.

But today,
today I muted it.

Honestly,
I'm proud of this kid.
I want to tell him this.
I want to tell him I'm glad.
that after thirteen years of learning,
the one thing he has not picked up on
is to blindly follow authority.

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I want to tell him this.
I want to tell him I'm sorry.
I'm sorry you're stuck in a broken system
where men in designer suits
who have never seen a classroom
keep cutting art out of the heart of education
because you can't express yourself
properly or profitably enough
through a color by letters
number two pencil
piss poor pointillist painting
like A, B, C, or D all of the above
is being held above all else.
I wanna tell him all of this.
I wanna tell him I'm sorry,
but I say,

"Sit down."

Sit down.
Save your strength, kid.

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Hold on to that crumpled paper, homemade bomb heart
that keeps blasting shards of chicken scratch shrapnel
through your blood stream.
Hold on to this
like sand bags for a real rainy day.

Trust me.
I know it hurts
It did and still does for me,
but there's a difference between
picking a fight and picking your fights.
Sit down.
This one's not worth it.
There are bigger fish to fry eyes with.
I'm temporary, kid..
I'm gone from your life
by the end of this period.
Then I'm off to who knows where
to substitute
all of their authority
and none of the mutual respect.

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All of their authority
and none of the time.
All of their authority
and none of the real chances
to make you listen,
so listen now,
"Sit down."
A cop's not gonna be so polite, kid.
You'll get nothing less than a slap on the jaw
with a night stick.
"Sit down."
There's something to be said for political captives,
but there's not much valor in a detention slip.
"Sit down."
And stand up
for something worth it.
Stand up strong for something worth it.
But for now,
"Sit down."

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I'm sorry.

I'm tired.

I spent all of yesterday

in a gang graffiti soaked, in-school suspension classroom

squared off with a seventh grade girl

with more balls than you'd know what to do with

and a blade in her backpack for the walk home.

"Sit down."

This tough guy act doesn't scare me.

For Christsake you're wearing 3D glasses with the

lenses popped out.

How am I supposed to take you seriously right now?

But seriously,

you might not get it now

and you probably think

I'm just some power trippin' jerk telling you what to do,

but really,

when I'm saying ""Sit down"

I'm praying you learn what it means to

stand up.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Kevin W. Burke
Book: Wish You Were Here
ISBN: N/A
Publisher: Kevin W. Burke
Date (Month/Year): 2011

NOTE: can be purchased on-line at
http://www.kevinwburkepoetry.com/store

NOTE: As of 1/26/2016 this book is out of stock on the author's website and is unable to be located for purchase at any other location. Use caution when performing in tournaments where proof of publication (ie original source) is required.

AWARD HISTORY

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